



A MAN walks by posters in Minneapolis for Renee Nicole Good, who was killed by a federal agent on Jan. 7.

Survivors of fire say utilities must pay

Citing state law, Edison expects to cover little of billions in Eaton damage.

By MELODY PETERSEN

A year after the Eaton fire, survivors and the state's electric utilities are clashing over whether state law should continue to protect the companies from the cost of disastrous wildfires they ignite.

Southern California Edison says that with the help of those state laws it expects to pay little or even none of the damage costs of the Eaton fire, which its equipment is suspected of sparking.

But in recent filings to state officials, fire victims and consumer advocates say the law has gone too far and made the utilities unaccountable for their mistakes, leading to even more fires.

"What do you think will happen if you constantly protect perpetrators of fires?" said Joy Chen, executive director of the Eaton Fire Survivors Network.

At the same time, Edison and the state's two other big for-profit electric companies are lobbying state officials for even more protection from the cost of future fires to reassure their investors.

If government investigators find Edison's equipment ignited the Eaton fire, at least seven of the state's 20 most destructive wildfires would have been caused by the three utilities' equipment.

The debate over how far the state should go to protect the electric companies from the cost of utility-sparked wildfires is playing out in Sacramento at the California Earthquake Authority. The authority is managing a broad study, ordered by Gov. Gavin Newsom, aimed at determining how to better protect Californians from catastrophic wildfires.

Chen said she was concerned by a meeting this [See Utilities, A12]

Lawmakers split over calls to 'abolish ICE'

Republicans have capitalized on the phrase's resurgence to paint Democrats as extremists

By Andrea Castillo and Ana Ceballos

WASHINGTON — "Abolish ICE." Democratic lawmakers and candidates for office around the country are increasingly returning to the phrase, popularized during the first Trump administration, as they react to the current administration's forceful immigration enforcement tactics.

The fatal shooting of 37-year-old Renee Nicole Good by an Immigration and Customs Enforcement agent this month in Minneapolis sparked immediate outrage among Democratic officials, who have proposed a variety of oversight

demands — including abolishing the agency — to rein in tactics they view as hostile and sometimes illegal.

Resurrecting the slogan is perhaps the riskiest approach. Republicans have pounced on the opportunity to paint Democrats, especially those in vulnerable seats, as extremists.

"If their response is to dust off 'defund ICE,' we're happy to take that fight any day of the week," said Christian Martinez, a spokesperson for the National Republican Congressional Committee. The [See ICE, A8]



A MICHOACÁN official near vehicles targeted by organized crime in November.

Migrants return to a Mexico transformed by drug cartels

U.S. deportees face risks in gang-controlled territory

By Steve Fisher and Kate Linthicum

MEXICO CITY — Adrián Ramírez hadn't been to his hometown in western Mexico for more than two decades. When he finally returned there early last year after being deported from the United States, he found the place transformed.

Ramírez remembered the town as vibrant. But the discotheque where he used to dance through the night in his 20s was gone. The

bustling evening market, where locals gather for tacos, now empties out early. After 10 p.m., cartel members wielding military-grade weapons take control of the streets.

"It is no longer the same Mexico of my childhood," said Ramírez, 45, who asked to be identified by his middle and last name for security reasons. "There was more joy, more freedom. But that's

not the case anymore."

Anyone returning to their hometown after decades away will note changes — old businesses close and new ones open, some people move away and others die. Adjusting to such shifts has long been part of the Mexican migrant experience.

But many of the tens of thousands of people who have been deported to Mexi- [See Mexico, A4]

State and L.A. initiatives seek to tax wealthiest

Focus on California's richest residents grows as affordability crisis, funding cuts play out.

By HAILEY BRANSON-POTTS AND NOAH GOLDBERG

California has billion-aires on the brain.

Last week union activists, hoisting giant cutouts of money bags and a cigar-smoking boss, announced a proposal to raise Los Angeles city taxes on companies with "overpaid" chief executives.

They rallied in front of a symbol of the uber rich: the futuristic, steel-covered Tesla Diner owned by Elon Musk, the world's richest man.

Meanwhile, a "billionaire tax" proposal prompted some of the wealthiest Californians to consider fleeing the state, amid arguments that they would take their tax revenue — and the companies they run — with them, hurting the ordinary residents the proposal is designed to help.

The focus on taxing the richest of the rich comes

amid a growing affordability crisis in California, home to the nation's most expensive housing market and highest income tax.

More than 200 billion-aires reside in California, more than any other state, according to a group of law and economics professors at UC Berkeley, UC Davis and the University of Missouri who helped draft the state-wide billionaire tax proposal, which proponents are hoping to place on the November ballot.

And they are getting richer. The collective wealth of the state's billionaires surged from \$300 billion in 2011 to \$2.2 trillion in October 2025, according to a December report by those professors. In Los Angeles, where the median sale price of \$1 million puts home ownership out of reach for many residents, prominent billionaires include David Geffen, Steven Spielberg and Magic Johnson.

One conspicuous billionaire is especially unpopular in California: President Trump, who, despite campaigning on bringing down the cost of living, recently called the word "affordability" a "con job" as he redeco- [See Wealth taxes, A10]

Trump trade shifts give China opening

Amid erratic policies, U.S. partners are considering deals with Beijing and others.

By PAUL WISEMAN

WASHINGTON — America's top trading partners are responding to President Trump's belligerent and unpredictable trade policies — including his announcement Saturday to impose tariffs on eight European allies for opposing U.S. designs on acquiring Greenland — by trying to take their business elsewhere.

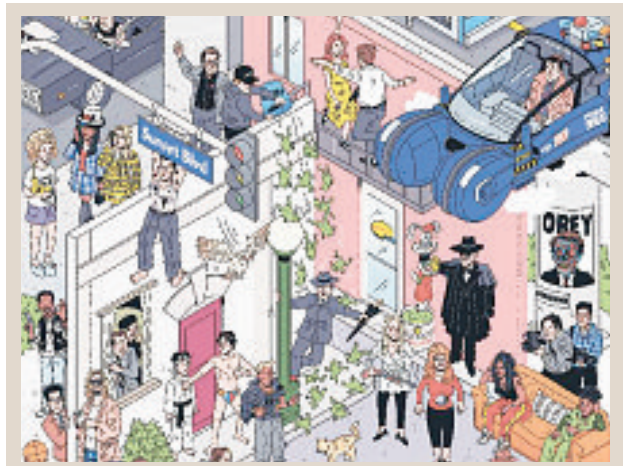
Canada broke with the United States on Friday, slashing its 100% import tax on Chinese electric vehicles

in return for lower tariffs on Canadian farm products, particularly canola seeds.

"It's a huge declaration of realignment in Canada's economic relations," said Edward Alden, who studies trade issues as senior fellow at the Council on Foreign Relations. "The economic threat from the United States is now perceived by Canadians as far bigger than the economic threat from China. So this is a big deal."

Canada repeatedly has been the target of Trump's impulsive wrath. In October, for instance, he said he was imposing a 10% tariff on Canadian imports as a reprisal for Ontario's provincial government airing an advertisement that criticized the president's go-to diplomatic [See China, A8]

New tariffs, new pact: Trump targets eight European nations for opposing his Greenland plans, and EU seals a free trade deal with a South American bloc. **A8**



LUKE MCGARRY For The Times

101 BEST L.A. MOVIES

Our list of essential films is as sprawling as our city, reeling in noir, Hollywood strivers and neighborhood dreamers. **ENTERTAINMENT**

Venezuela leader on DEA's radar

Acting President Delcy Rodríguez's name has appeared in multiple investigations, records show. **WORLD, A6**

Weather

Sunny and warm. L.A. Basin: 80/52. **B8**

Business **A13**
Opinion Voices **A16**

Caruso's choice? Neither race

Developer, after much speculation, won't run for governor or L.A. mayor. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

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Foraging for mushrooms, with deadly results

By KAREN GARCIA

An exceptionally wet December contributed to an abundance of death cap mushrooms, or *Amanita phalloides*, on the Central Coast and Northern California, causing what officials describe as an unprecedented

ed outbreak of severe illness and death among people who consume the fungi.

Public health officials are issuing a second warning this winter, this time urging the public against foraging for wild mushrooms, noting that many people have mistakenly eaten the death cap, which when consumed can

cause severe liver damage and in some cases death.

In the last 26 years, "we have not had a season as deadly as this season both in terms of the total numbers of cases as well as deaths and liver transplants," said Craig Smollin, medical director of the San Francisco division of the California

Poison Control System.

"I believe this is probably the largest outbreak that we've seen in California, ever."

Many of the cases, officials say, involved people from Mexico and elsewhere for whom the death cap resembles an edible mushroom. [See Mushrooms, A12]